The crowds at Gandhi Maidan and beyond had discovered a Modi trying to unshackle himself from a contentious past and evolve into the hope for the future. The chanting was almost frenzied—the crowd wanted more. A rally per se doesn't define an election campaign but Modi's Patna rally, with all the controversy swirling around it, was a landmark event. It gave the BJP the confidence that its leader could evoke a feverish response even in unfamiliar territory. 'Till that day, we were looking at the election from the point of view of conventional arithmetic. From that moment on, it was all about chemistry,' says Jaitley.

That very day, around the same time as the Modi rally, Rahul Gandhi addressed an election rally in Mangolpuri in Delhi. Most news channels kept it on mute, or ignored it altogether while focusing on Modi. There was to be only one obvious winner that day. Sitting at home and watching the events unfold, Nitish Kumar must have been a worried man. His government faced the serious charge of having provided lax security to his main political rival. A new hero had entered the Bihar drama. Post-blast emotionalism, surcharged TV debates on the threat to Modi's life and consequent disillusionment with administrative measures began to gather momentum. The battle for Bihar was about to be lost.

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Some relationships are just not meant to be. The equation between Modi and Nitish Kumar is one such. I remember asking Nitish over dinner a few years ago what was it about Modi that enraged him so much. *'Isse kisi vyakti se mat jodiye . . . yeh **Kisi** vyakti vishesh nahi hai, yeh ek vichardhara ki ladai hai . . . Yeh desh secular hai aur secular rahega . . . kuch logon ko yeh pata hona chahiye . . .'* (Please don't link this to an individual, this is about an ideology. This is a secular country and will always remain one, some people must understand this), was his response. Typically, he did not refer to Modi by name; he would always refer to him in the third person.

But this was not just a simple 'secular' versus 'communal' divide, as Nitish would have us believe. When the 2002 Gujarat riots occurred, Nitish